

UK green bank

The UK govt. is all set to launch a three billion dollar bank to help Britain go low carbon

Reach for rechargeables

Many people continue to use disposable pencil cells, when shifting to rechargeable batteries would be much cheaper and greener

Entrepreneurship

space. Dr Bell loved the idea and started Amerigon Electric Vehicles (AEV) in California in 1991. I worked with him before joining Stanford University for a masters degree in mechanical engineering. After I graduated, I went back to work for him full time. Over the years that I stayed there, I helped develop and design electric and hybrid vehicles.

In 1994, I started work on Reva as a joint venture between the Maini Group, founded by my father, and AEV. The first car rolled out in 2001. A lot happened in the interim. While I was in the US, in 1997, California did not mandate the regulation that would have made sure that 2% of all vehicles sold in the state would have to be zero-emission vehicles. The decision spelt doom for the electric vehicle space. I was sure that the Reva would not happen now. But my family would not let me give up. They pushed me to go ahead with the plans. Things, however, were not that simple anymore. I could not be just a technologist. I had to chase financial organisations for money and had to become an entrepreneur. Reva was a big emotional and financial commitment for us.

Our first assembly plant was clean and green. The design was a challenge since everything had to be low on investment, yet flexible. We used the "rolling chassis" model instead of the conventional fixed assembly line. Wheels were fixed on to the chassis, which moved from station to station for assembly.

Innovation drives me and research is at the core of every-

thing we do. Reva's first seven years were focused on development. We have more than 10 patents in battery and energy management systems. Reva is a ground-up electric vehicle, not a converted hybrid like other cars in the market. Our new model, the Reva NXR, is built on next generation lithium-ion batteries.

In the last five years, there has been a lot of change. Consumers, governments and automotive players have changed – not just in India, but worldwide. Now, people talk about auto emissions, city pollution and climate change. There are concerns about rising fuel costs and fuel shortage. International summits are abuzz with talks

WIN EXCITING PRIZES



Digit's Facebook Apps Contest

What you learn from this Fast Track could win you Rs. 20,000 in exciting prizes. Take part in Digit's Facebook Apps contest by going to

www.thinkdigit.com/d/fb_contest

and discussions on fuel-efficient technology, hybrid and electric vehicles.

It's actually London that set the ball rolling. Reva went on sale in Britain in 2004 as the



Photography: Gireesh GV

Very Verte, Maini has just set up a new plant in Bangalore, and is preparing to floor the production pedal

G-Wiz. There are over a thousand cars on London roads. The city has set a fine example. Electric vehicles, even tax exemptions, and free parking and charging facilities for car owners. On and off-the-street charging stations have been introduced across the city. Our London story has encouraged other manufacturers. There are now more than 50 EV brands under development across the world.

The Frankfurt Motor Show 2009 was a big high. We were the only Indian company participating there, and showcasing new technology. We launched two new models, a four-seater family car, Reva NXR, and a two-seater sports car, Reva NXG. We got a great response from the customers and the media.

I am excited about all this. Our business model now goes beyond just being electric vehicle manufacturers. We are licensing our technology and have partnered with GM India to bring out a battery-powered version of their Chevrolet Spark. GM

shares our passion for reducing carbon emissions. Also, it has the expertise and ability to develop platforms.

I want to press the accelerator now. Our new plant in Bangalore has a capacity of 30,000 vehicles. It should be ready by the year-end. I want it to be an industry benchmark. It follows the Indian Green Building Council guidelines and our "born green" philosophy.

I believe nothing can stop you if you believe in your idea. I faced a lot of skepticism when I started. People did not take us seriously, and would test drive the car for fun. Then things began changing. In 2006, I received an investment of US\$20 million from Draper Fisher Jurveston and Global Environment Fund to grow Reva globally.

Thankfully, I never wanted to do anything else even when things weren't going well. I don't stay disheartened for long, a couple of hours at most. A good night's sleep and I am determined to go at things again. 

Content courtesy:

India